

How can a purchaser/funder make sure that a supplier/provider is implementing an initiative well?

When a purchaser/funder funds or contracts a supplier/provider to deliver an initiative, the purchaser/funder obviously wants to maximize the chances of the initiative having an impact on outcomes.

Often, the purchaser/funder relies on reports from the supplier/provider to monitor that it is making progress. This traditional approach can be complemented by the purchaser/funder setting up a formal parallel implementation evaluation process (also called formative evaluation) to work with the initiative to optimize its implementation. How this works is set out in this Independent Parallel Implementation Evaluation Tool (F2). In such cases, in addition to funding the initiative, the purchaser/funder also funds an independent organization to do the implementation evaluation of the quality of the initiative's implementation.

The independent implementation evaluator(s) play the role of being a 'critical friend' to the initiative being implemented. Their job is to 'assess' the initiative, but then, on the basis of the assessment findings to also 'assist' it to do better. Also see When to Include an 'Assist' plus an 'Assess' Mode in Contracting Checklist (E7). Implementation evaluators use standard implementation evaluation techniques – DoView strategy/outcomes diagram building, interviews with staff and stakeholders, indicator monitoring, document analysis to develop a view of how the implementation is going, and impact evaluation on parts of the initiative. See Evaluation Data Collection Types (G20). Usually, the initiative has not been going long enough for impact evaluation on the whole initiative to show results, but the role of the implementation evaluation is to provide information for 'course correction' before it is too late to change. The implementation evaluators then formally present their information to the initiative's governance group on a regular basis (e.g. every three months). Also, they often provide informal advice between formal reports directly to the initiative.

The implementation evaluation can also be set up so that the implementation evaluators also send a copy of their regular implementation evaluation reports to the initiative's purchaser/funder agency. This provides the initiative's purchaser/funder with an independent view of how well the initiative is going with its implementation.